THE POWER OF

ONE PERCENT BETTER

SMALL GAINS, MAXIMUM RESULTS

THOMAS OPPONG

The Power of One Percent Better

Small Gains, Maximum Results

Thomas Oppong

Uncopyright 2017. By Thomas Oppong

This ebook is uncopyrighted. Feel free to take passages from this ebook and replicate them online. Use my content however you want! Email it, share it, reprint it with or without credit. Attribution is appreciated but not required. Portions of this book have appeared previously at Medium.com

I'd prefer people buy my ebooks, but if they want to share with their audience, they can go ahead. If someone wants to take my work and improve upon it, as artists have been doing for centuries, I think that's a wonderful thing.

Other books by Thomas Oppong

Start. Make. Create. Do.

Building Smarter Habits

This Will Make Your Life Simpler

Bet on Yourself

I also exist outside of this ebook

Founder at Alltopstartups.com (resources for starting and growing a startup)

Curator at Postanly.com (science-based self-improvement and productivity posts from around the web delivered weekly)

Columnist @Inc., Contributor @Entrepreneur, @HuffingtonPost, @Qz and @Observer

Get to know me: Twitter, LinkedIn

Content

Introduction

The Kaizen Approach to Self-improvement: Get 1% Better Every Day

The Art of Purposeful Practice

The Little Rules of Action

How to be Super Productive Every Day Without Losing Your Mind

Little Habits That Can Change Your Life

The Hidden Habit Skills

The Most Important Life Skills

The Doing Mindset > The Thinking Mindset

These Habits Will Immediately Improve How You Work

The First 90 Minutes Rule

Harsh Truths About Getting Things Done

The Pomodoro Technique to 10x Results

The Cross Calendar Approach to Building Consistent Habits (Seinfeld Strategy)

Productivity Techniques for Peak Performance

The One Thing That is a Better Indicator of Your Success Than Talent

The Art of Purposeful Practice (Not All Practice Makes Perfect)

The “Do Something” Mindset (The Power of Practicing More)

The Price of Success

Overcoming Distraction

Motivate Yourself to Do (and Achieve) Anything With These Thoughts

Timeless And Generally Applicable Pieces of Wisdom

These Sites Can Help You Get Better Everyday

Introduction

Small wins, marginal gains. That's how long-term habits are formed. if you improve every area of your life in small steps, you will become unstoppable. The one percent margin for improvement in everything you do is one of the best ways to build new habits. It's so easy to overestimate the importance of one defining moment and underestimate the value of making small gains on a daily basis. Everything meaningful takes time. Overnight success is a myth. You can't achieve extraordinary results without putting in the work consistently.

Almost every habit that you have built over the years— good or bad — is the result of many small decisions you have made over time. Improving by just 1 percent isn't noticeable but it makes the most difference. Jim Rohn once said "Success is a few simple disciplines, practiced every day; while failure is simply a few errors in judgment, repeated every day. There is power in small wins and slow gains.

The differences between expert performers, creatives, and normal professionals reflect a life-long persistence of deliberate, purposeful effort to improve performance. Tiger Woods started when he was 2 years old. Serena Williams started playing at 3, Venus Williams at 4. They committed to deep, sustained immersion in purposeful practice. Small gains every day.

Commander Hadfield, the astronaut, improved his skills every day for 20 years before getting into space. Kurt Vonnegut wrote every day for 25 years before he had a major bestseller. Mozart had clocked up 3500 hours by the time he was 6 and had studied his chosen profession for 18 years before he wrote his Piano concerto No 9 at the age of 21.

Einstein spent almost all his productive life working on the theory of relativity. Nobody wins in huge bursts. “Landing on your butt twenty thousand times is where great performance comes from” says Geoff Calvin.

One mistake people make over and over when they want to get more do or achieve a goal is trying to do too much all at once. Productivity is a process, not an achievement. The most productive people you know or have read about do not rely on huge bursts and then stop working. They grow constantly in tiny, almost invisible increments.

This is the Japanese process of kaizen, or continuous, gradual progress. Kaizen can be used to build new habits or change bad ones. The same process applies to starting a business or learning something new. It is better to make an imperfect, incomplete start with a new app or project and become 1% more efficient tomorrow than to wait until you have fully researched your options or understand the industry to take action

Instead of trying to do everything within the shortest time, focus on 1% increments. Habits don’t change in a day. But 1% a day makes every habit work. Every. If you relax and give yourself permission to only improve a little each day, then a good habit works. Practice makes habits. If you insist the habit changes within the shortest possible time, you are bound to fail. Pick the easiest change, improve it each day by 1% and don’t stop until it’s routine. That’s how change happens. Do not underestimate the power of micro-improvements.

Improving by 1 percent every day or week is achievable – regardless of your circumstances. If you’re currently encountering resistance with your goals, remember the words of Karen Lamb: “A year from now, you will have wished you’d started today”.

The Kaizen Approach to Self-improvement: Get 1% Better Every Day

"Compounding is the greatest mathematical discovery of all time." — Albert Einstein

The quest to become a better version of yourself often feels like a roller coaster ride. It's hard. And it's usually so uneven. You can end in failure. But life is a journey, not a marathon, so you always have another opportunity to start over and improve.

Many people practically look out for secrets, tricks, and hacks that will make EVERYTHING better right now. But unfortunately life doesn't work that way.There are no "overnight successes". Think of all the incredible people you truly admire. They didn't succeed because of one giant move, but rather a series of small and consistent actions over time.

Baby steps, baby.
Inertia is a very strong force. I've said it before, but this is a very important step here: the best way to change is through baby steps. One small step at a time. Don't try to bite off too much. How is this different from the above step, setting a small and achievable goal? It's the same concept, but extended beyond the initial goal. It's taking things one little goal at a time, a bit at a time. For example, let's say you want to run a marathon, but currently your running regimen consists of running to the bathroom during commercial breaks while you're watching Lost.

So do you go out and start a marathon training plan? Nope. You start by walking 10 minutes a day. Then, when that becomes a habit and too easy, walk 15 minutes. Then 20, then 30. Then jog a minute, walk a couple minutes, jog a minute, and so on, for those 30 minutes. Then jog 90 seconds, and so on, until you're running for 30 minutes. Do these steps a week or two at a time, so that all of a sudden, you're running for 45 minutes every other day ... and you barely noticed the progression. That's the way you

get to a goal ... small progressions that are barely noticeable. Not by killing yourself the first day out.

Just keep doing it, no matter what.
You'll encounter obstacles, and falter and fall. Just get up and keep going. You'll face temptations and give in. That's OK. Just keep going. You'll make mistakes and get discouraged. No matter ... just keep going. Learn from your mistakes, and ... keep going. No matter what happens, keep going. If you're taking baby steps, you're holding yourself accountable, and you're actually doing something, you'll get there.

Stop aiming for radical personal change!

"Be patient with yourself. Self-growth is tender; it's holy ground. There's no greater investment." — Stephen Covey

A magic bullet cannot save you! You've got to embrace the process and enjoy it. You can't escape the hard work it takes to get better. Every incredibly successful person you know today has been through the boring, mundane, time-tested process that eventually brings success. So, stop looking for "quick hacks" that bring faster results.

Instead of reading every self-improvement post for the one golden tip that will make you superhumanly efficient, focus on doing the actual work that needs to be done. You can inspire yourself to take action. The hard, long process is the only way though. You can't achieve tremendous life success with a quick fix. Nobody gets it that easy.

Your big, audacious goals are not inspiring you!

"Whoever wants to reach a distant goal must take small steps." — Helmut Schmidt

Your attempt to be better usually ends in failure because you life-changing goals overwhelm you into inaction instead of inspiring you into action. Unrealistic goals make it insanely difficult to make any progress. You will get “stressed” over what is supposed to help you take action.

Your performance and ability to get things done is inextricably bound to brain performance. A big, audacious goal looks scary to your brain. And when your brain encounters scary, it goes into “freeze” mode. You don’t want that. If you constantly overstretch yourself, you will lose the required energy you need to take the necessary action to get better.

Setting a goal, no matter how simple is always the easy part. Everyone has goals. The real challenge is not determining if you want the result, but if you are willing to accept the sacrifices required to achieve your goals.

If you want to achieve your goals at all times, create a system that works. Instead of a goal, design a great system or process. That way, you will always win. Even when your short-term goals are achieved, your next goal won’t be a struggle. Having a system is what matters. Committing to the process makes a huge difference.

James Clear explains:

We place unnecessary stress on ourselves to lose weight or to succeed in business or to write a best-selling novel. Instead, you can keep things simple and reduce stress by focusing on the daily process and sticking to your schedule, rather than worrying about the big, life-changing goals. When you focus on the practice instead of the performance, you can enjoy the present moment and improve at the same time.

Self-improvement is not a destination!

"You will never change your life until you change something you do daily"—Mike Murdock

Learning should not end after formal education. Lifelong learning, the ongoing, voluntary, and self-motivated pursuit of knowledge can enrich your life and make you a better person every day.

Self-improvement isn't a destination. You're never done. Even if you have some success, and you want to maintain it, you have to keep doing the things you were doing that got you that success in the first place.

Your first step to improving your life and becoming the best version of yourself won't be easy. Nobody can promise you that things will be easy but they will get better. It pays to take a small action–any action–and grow from there. Remember, you are better off trying and crawling than anyone else who isn't trying.

The Kaizen Approach and how it works

"Little strokes fell great oaks." –Benjamin Franklin

Kaizen — Japanese for continuous improvement

It was developed by Depression-era American business management theorists in order to build the arsenal of democracy that helped the U.S. win World War II. The Japanese took to the idea of small, continual improvement right away and gave it a name: *Kaizen* — Japanese for continuous improvement.

While Kaizen was originally developed to help businesses improve and thrive, it's just as applicable to our personal lives.

The idea here is to focus on consistent improvements in your life, every day, not matter how small the step you take to be a better you than you were yesterday.

According to Brett and Kate McKay of *The Art of Manliness:*

"Instead of trying to make radical changes in a short amount of time, just make small improvements every day that will gradually lead to the change you want.Each day, just focus on getting 1% better in whatever it is you're trying to improve. That's it. Just 1%.

It might not seem like much, but those 1% improvements start compounding on each other. In the beginning, your improvements will be so small as to seem practically nonexistent. But gradually and ever so slowly, you'll start to notice the improvements in your life. It may take months or even years, but the improvements will come if you just focus on consistently upping your game by 1%."

Here is why Kaizen works

"When you improve a little each day, eventually big things occur. When you improve conditioning a little each day, eventually you have a big improvement in conditioning. Not tomorrow, not the next day, but eventually a big gain is made. Don't look for the big, quick improvement. Seek the small improvement one day at a time. That's the only way it happens — and when it happens, it lasts." — John Wooden

The Kaizen approach is a reminder that all improvements must be maintained if we wish to secure consistent gains. Think of the smallest step you can take every day that would move you incrementally towards your goal.

Becoming 1% better every day is a simple, practical way to achieve big goals.1% seems like a small amount. Yes, it is. It's tiny. It's easy. It's doable. And it's applicable in most things you want to do or accomplish.

It feels less intimidating and is more manageable. It might feel less exciting than chasing a huge win, but its results will be stronger and more sustainable.

The Art of Purposeful Practice

"If we follow the mastery process long enough, inspired by a profound interest and curiosity we cannot fail to achieve something exceptional." — Robert Greene

Purposeful practice is serving the tennis ball 20, 35, or 50 times until the serve is "near perfect". It is working on a piano scales every day without fail until the fingering is so automatic, the fingers fly across the keys. It is committing to something so many times that it becomes a purposeful routine that gets you closer to mastery.

You become so good, they can't ignore you. These practices, whether guided or independent, provides the kind of extended learning needed to hone your craft. It's the ultimate process that leads to mastery.

Purposeful practice demands focus and intense concentration on a skill, problem, or even a project beyond the ordinary. It is a long-term commitment with a single goal in mind. Every activity is strategically designed to purposefully improve performance.

The difference between proficient and expert performances often depends on the amount and quality of practice.

Quantity > Quality...for beginners!

"Landing on your butt twenty thousand times is where great performance comes from" — Geoff Calvin

The extraordinary commitment of the young Mozart, under the guidance of his father produced one of the most prolific and influential composers of the classical era. Mozart, despite being a prodigy, wrote music for 10 years every day before becoming a true master.

Improve a little each day. It compounds. When 1% compounds every day, it doubles every 72 days, not every 100 days. Compounding tiny excellence is what creates big excellence. Top athletes don't become experts at what they do by simply practicing; they get there through purposeful practice.

Uncommon achievement requires an uncommon level of grit and a massive amount of hard work even when you keep failing. You need a deeper connection to stay on the same path for years.

Anyone can achieve mastery with purposeful practice. With considerable, specific, and sustained efforts over time, you can do most things you struggle with. You can only turn into the expert you want to become by deliberate, purposeful practice.

You've got to respect the process!

"There are really three parts to the creative process. First there is inspiration, then there is the execution, and finally there is the release." — Eddie Van Halen

The ability to show up everyday even when you are not motivated to learn, create, make something is the most valuable trait you need to be a professional. It doesn't come easy but it's a requirement to survive the process of creating or doing something unique and remarkable.

Mastering anything usually involves exploration, adjustment, and improvisation. You can't always know your destination in advance. And that's okay.

But be prepared for constant average work to get better at mastering the skill you have chosen to master. Give yourself permission to screw up and move on when things don't go as plans.

You can't create a masterpiece without creative mess. Whatever you intend to master now or in the future, you need to prepare yourself for the long haul. And that means hundreds of thousands of hours will be spent making mistakes and starting over. And that's okay. One of the greatest impediments to creativity is impatience. It pays to value and embrace the creative process. It's the only way to master any skill.

Excellence comes from constantly stretching to reach a much higher goal.

"Mediocrity will never do. You are capable of something better." — Gordon B.Hinckley

Purposeful practice builds new neural pathways. You can move the boundary of your comfort bubble to accommodate new routines that will contribute to your growth.

Anders Ericsson and Robert Pool explains*: "The most effective and most powerful types of practice in any field work by harnessing the adaptability of the human body and brain to create, step by step, the ability to do things that were previously not possible."*

People who achieve extraordinary results put in a lot more hours to practice than the rest of us. But while their performances and what they do are remarkable, there is no mystery at all about how they developed them. They practiced. A lot. Beyond the ordinary.

This increase in the amount and sophistication of practice resulted in a steady improvement over time. And even they become masters and experts, they don't stop practicing to deliver even amazing results expected of them.

Arsene Wenger (Manager at Arsenal Football Club) once said:

"To perform at your maximum, you have to teach yourself to believe with an intensity that goes way beyond logical justification. No top performer has lacked this capacity for irrational optimism.

Consistency and a series of purposeful actions will transform the way you work and hone in your chosen craft.

The Little Rules of Action

"The shortest answer is doing." – Lord Herbert

Too often we get stuck in inaction — the quagmire of doubt and perfectionism and distractions and planning that stops us from moving forward.
And while I'm no proponent of a whirling buzz of activity, I also believe people get lost in the distractions of the world and lose sight of what's important, and how to actually accomplish their Something Amazing.

And so today I'd like to humbly present a few little rules of action — just some small reminders, things I've found useful but by no means invented, common-sense stuff that is often not common enough.

1. Don't overthink. Too much thinking often results in getting stuck, in going in circles. Some thinking is good — it's good to have a clear picture of where you're going or why you're doing this — but don't get stuck thinking. Just do.

2. Just start. All the planning in the world will get you nowhere. You need to take that first step, no matter how small or how shaky. My rule for motivating myself to run is: Just lace up your shoes and get out the door. The rest takes care of itself.

3. Forget perfection. Perfectionism is the enemy of action. Kill it, immediately. You can't let perfect stop you from doing. You can turn a bad draft into a good one, but you can't turn no draft into a good draft. So get going.

4. Don't mistake motion for action. A common mistake. A fury of activity doesn't mean you're doing anything. When you find yourself moving too quickly, doing too many things at once, this is a good reminder to stop. Slow down. Focus.

5. Focus on the important actions. Clear the distractions. Pick the one most important thing you must do today, and focus on that. Exclusively. When you're done with that, repeat the process.

6. Move slowly, consciously. Be deliberate. Action doesn't need to be done fast. In fact, that often leads to mistakes, and while perfection isn't at all necessary, neither is making a ridiculous amount of mistakes that could be avoided with a bit of consciousness.

7. Take small steps. Biting off more than you can chew will kill the action. Maybe because of choking, I dunno. But small steps always works. Little tiny blows that will eventually break down that mountain. And each step is a victory, that will compel you to further victories.

8. Negative thinking gets you nowhere. Seriously, stop doing that. Self doubt? The urge to quit? Telling yourself that it's OK to be distracted and that you can always get to it later? Squash those thoughts. Well, OK, you can be distracted for a little bit, but you get the idea. Positive thinking, as corny as it sounds, really works. It's self-talk, and what we tell ourselves has a funny habit of turning into reality.

9. Meetings aren't action. This is a common mistake in management. They hold meetings to get things done. Meetings, unfortunately, almost always get in the way of actual doing. Stop holding those meetings!

10. Talking (usually) isn't action. Well, unless the action you need to take is a presentation or speech or something. Or you're a television broadcaster. But usually, talking is just talking. Communication is necessary, but don't mistake it for actual action.

11. Planning isn't action. Sure, you need to plan. Do it, so you're clear about what you're doing. Just do it quickly, and get to the actual action as quickly as you can.

12. Reading about it isn't action. You're reading an article about action. Ironic, I know. But let this be the last one. Now get to work!

13. Sometimes, inaction is better. This might be the most ironic thing on the list, but really, if you find yourself spinning your wheels, or you find you're doing more harm

than good, rethink whether the action is even necessary. Or better yet, do this from the beginning — is it necessary? Only do the action if it is.

"Talk doesn't cook rice." – Chinese Proverb

How to be Super Productive Every Day Without Losing Your Mind

"Nothing is less productive than to make more efficient what should not be done at all." — Peter Drucker

You will work better when you find and stick to habits that work best for you. You can't use every productive habit you read about. The most insanely productive people stick to habits that produce the most results. They consistently act purposefully in order to maximize every minute of every day. You can achieve high performance if you focus on the right things at the right time. Here are five ways to do more every week.

1. A productive day begins with a focused mind

"You don't need a new plan for next year. You need a commitment." — Seth Godin

Distractions begin as a thought. Don't allow your mind to wander at your peak times. You don't want to be disorganized when you should be focusing on your work. It's very hard to concentrate and be productive when you are constantly distracted. An organized mind can get most things done in a short time because you lose yourself in the process of work.

One of the best ways to maintain focus is to find a comfortable position at your desk and don't allow yourself to move or get distracted easily. Stay away from physical distractions and focus your thoughts on the task. After a while, your mental energy will be channeled completely into your work until it's done.

A disorganized mind on the other hand robs you of your ability to completely immerse yourself in your tasks to get them done on time. Your choices, decisions, and ability to be creative also suffer when your mind is in an invasive state. You can also easily get distracted when you tackle insanely easy or extremely difficult tasks.

2. Master your time to master your life

"Once you have mastered time, you will understand how true it is that most people overestimate what they can accomplish in a year — and underestimate what they can achieve in a decade!" — Tony Robbins

You have an average of 2,400 minutes every week to yourself. Time is your most valuable asset at work. And time spent can never be reclaimed. A lot can be achieved every week if you know what you are doing at any point in time.

Ultra productive people focus on getting a lot done with every minute they have at their disposal. Allocate time to each task you need to get done every day. Each task of the day should be attainable, realistic, and time-bound.The time constraint will push you to focus and be more efficient.

Don't forget to allow downtime between tasks to refresh. Go for a short walk, read a book, or listen to a podcast. Choose a mind-clearing activity that works best for you. Your brain needs a short break to recuperate, and then you are ready to move on to another task.

3. Your weekly tasks should contribute to a meaningful and greater goal

"Don't confuse the urgent with the important." — Preston Ni

Find out how your everyday tasks fit into larger goals and aspirations of your business or project to keep you motivated to complete what you start each week. If you can't find a reason why your work matters, the probability of leaving tasks undone until next week will be very high.

According to Charles Duhigg, author of *Smarter Faster Better*, reminding ourselves of how a small action fits into a bigger objective makes it easier to link our small efforts to more meaningful aspirations.

This discovery can help you complete even the most boring tasks of the day because you know it's part of something bigger than yourself. Your contribution can help your company achieve its monthly or annual goals.

4. Focus on the ONE thing that needs to be done every workday

"Working on the right thing is probably more important than working hard." — Caterina Fake

Chances are, you have a lot to do every day but you are probably not getting all of the tasks done within the day. Take the first 30 minutes each day to schedule what needs to be done for the day.

What is the very important task on your calendar that needs to be done today? Get that figured out first thing in the morning. Start your day by tackling high-value tasks you can complete in the morning. This will keep you motivated to get the next task done in time.

Use the same mindset to handle difficult tasks tomorrow and the rest of the week. Do the most difficult tasks at your most productive hour. Most people can get a lot done before noon. Figure out the time that brings out the best in you and concentrate on getting stuff done at that time.

5. Don't work on a task more than once

"Simplicity boils down to two steps: Identify the essential. Eliminate the rest."

— Leo Babauta

Don't put things on hold only to deal with them again later. Learn to handle incoming tasks once and move on. How many times have you opened the same email only to close it and open it again at another time? Don't save an email or a phone call to deal with later.

Once something new gets your attention, if it's not on your list of things to do within the day you should delegate it or reply, if it takes no more than a few minutes to respond to it. If it takes more than five minutes, you are better off scheduling it for another time or day. You don't want to be distracted while you're in the flow.

Little Habits That Can Change Your Life

"We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence then, is not an act, but a habit." – Aristotle

If you could just pick one or two (or seven) habits to create in the next few months — habits that will have the most impact on your life — what would they be?
I often get asked this question, because people are overwhelmed when it comes to starting positive life changes. They ask me: what one or two habits should they start with? It's not an easy question.

"Men's natures are alike; it is their habits that separate them." – Confucius

Here are the basics:

- Do a 30-day challenge, focusing on just ONE habit.
- Write it out on paper, along with your motivations, obstacles, and strategies for overcoming them.
- Commit fully, in a public way.
- Log your progress.
- Remain publicly accountable — report on your progress each day.
- Have support for when you falter — either in real life or online.
- Reward every little success.
- If you fail, figure out what went wrong, plan for it, and try again.

The Little Habits That Can Change Your Life
OK, so now you know how to form a habit — and remember, only do them one at a time — but you want to know the seven little habits. Here they are, in my order of preference (but yours may be different):

1. Develop positive thinking. I put this first because I think it's the keystone habit that will help you form the other important habits. Sure, positive thinking by itself won't lead to success, but it certainly goes a long way to motivate you to do the other things required. Focus on this habit first, and you'll have a much easier time with any of the others. Start by becoming more aware of your negative self-talk — do a little tally sheet throughout the day, marking a tally each time you notice a negative thought. Soon you'll recognize them, and you can squash them.

2. Exercise. Sure, exercise is healthy and all that, but how exactly is it life changing? I'm glad you asked:

- It makes you feel better about yourself, and more confident. That leads to better success with other positive changes.
- It reinforces the positive thinking habit — you need to think positive in order to sustain exercise.
- It relieves stress and gives you time to think — this leads to better mental well-being in your life overall.
- It helps with creativity. Don't ask me to prove it, except to say that my best ideas and brainstorming sessions come from when I exercise.

3. Set a small, achievable goal. Remember, inertia is a powerful force. If you haven't been exercising for a couple years, it's hard to get started. You're used to the way things are, and even if you want to change, it's difficult. So don't start out trying to conquer the world. Just conquer something exceedingly small. It might sound wimpy to say, "I'm going to walk for 10 minutes" or "I'm going to do 10 pushups and 1 chinup", but those are much more likely to beat inertia than, "I'm going to exercise for 45 minutes today." Be realistic, and make it very very achievable. It's the only way to beat inertia.

"Try not. Do or do not. There is no try." – Yoda in The Empire Strikes Back

4. Single-tasking. The opposite of multitasking — you've heard me harp on about this one as well. Why is it life-changing? A couple powerful reasons:

- You'll be more effective with your tasks and get more done. It's hard to achieve important things if you're constantly switching tasks and distracted by other "urgent" things.
- You'll be less stressed overall and (in my experience) happier throughout your day.

5. Focus on one goal. Just as focusing on one task at a time is more effective, and focusing on one habit at a time is more effect, so is focusing on one goal at a time. While it might seem very difficult, focusing on one goal at a time is the most powerful way of achieving your goals. When you try to take on many goals at once, you're spreading thin your focus and energy — the two critical components for achieving a goal.

What if you have 5 goals you want to achieve? Pick one to focus on first. Break it into a mini-goal you can accomplish this month, if it's a longer-term goal. Pick an action you can do today. Keep doing this until the goal is accomplished — do an action every day, finish the mini-goal, pick the next mini-goal to work on. Then, when your One Goal is completed, focus on the next goal.

Some goals are ongoing ones — like blogging every day, or exercising every day. In those cases, turn them into habits — focus exclusively on turning the goal into a habit, until the habit is ingrained. Then focus on the next goal.

6. Eliminate the non-essential. First, identify the essential — the things in your life that are most important to you, that you love the most. Then eliminate everything else. This simplifies things and leaves you with the space to focus on the essential. This process works with anything — with your life in general, with work projects and tasks, with emails and other communication.
This will change your life because it will help you to simplify, to focus on what's important, and to build the life you want.

6. Daily routine. It's so simple, but creating a daily routine for yourself can make a big difference in your life. The best routines, I've found, come at the start and end of the day — both your workday and your day in general. That means, develop a routine for

when you awake, for when you first start working, for when you finish your workday, and for the end of your evening.

How will that change your life? It will help you get a great start to your day, and finish your day by preparing for the next day. It'll help you firmly root the productive habits you want to firm in your everyday life. It'll help you focus on what's important, not just what comes up. It'll help you make sure you get done all the things you really want to make sure gets done everyday. And that can mean a lot.

The Hidden Habit Skills

"We first make our habits, and then our habits make us." – John Dryden

When you learn a new skill, feedback is important: if you fall off a bike, you need to make an adjustment so you don't keep falling. But when people learn the skill of creating new habits, they usually take the feedback of missing the habit as complete failure. A sign that they have no discipline. In actuality, it means no such thing. It just means you need to practice the skill more and make an adjustment.

What people don't realize is that creating habits is actually a skillset that can be learned and practiced and mastered. Work on these skills.

1. Committing to actually starting. Lots of people think, "I should learn a language," or "I'm going to start exercising soon" ... but then don't actually take action. That's because they haven't really committed to getting started. In our minds, we half commit to things all the time. The habit skill to master is fully committing. That means overcoming your mind's resistance to taking action, and saying, "I'm doing this. I'm all in. I'm going to start today." And then get moving. If you're not good at doing this, start your practice right now: commit to making a small habit change, right this second.

2. Focus on starting. Once you've chosen your habit, and are ready to get started ... the focus should be on actually doing the habit. There's a resistance we face many times when we're supposed to do a new habit, and we procrastinate, run to distractions, and rationalize. The skill to master is getting started. You don't have to exercise for 30 minutes ... you just need to start. Most people are not good at this, and they think it's because they have no willpower. No. They just haven't practiced and mastered this skill of starting.

3. Noticing rationalizations. Our minds resist doing the habit, and come up with all kinds of rationalizations: It's too hard, there's no need to put yourself through this suffering, you'll do it later, you deserve a break, just this once won't hurt. We've all done this, many times. The skill to master is seeing this rationalization process in action. Be mindful of it. Expose it to the sunlight of attention. And then, come up with counterarguments for each rationalization.

4. Constant re-adjustment. This is one of the most important habit skills of all, but people fail to do it. They have a rigid idea of what their habit will be like, and when something doesn't go according to plan, they feel like everything has failed. They feel guilt, and think they're a failure. No. They just need to re-adjust, and have a flexible mindset. This is so important, and yet almost no one does it. Forget to do the habit? No problem! Adjust by coming up with reminders. Procrastinated by going on Facebook? No problem! Adjust by blocking Facebook until 5p.m. No problem is a problem if you have the skill of re-adjustment.

If you're not good at creating habits, you simply need to practice these four hidden skills. If you mess up, just practice some more. No one mastered anything on their first few attempts — it takes time to get good at anything. But if you get good at this, you can unlock almost unlimited achievements. That makes it worth practicing.

The Most Important Life Skills

Every skill you acquire doubles your odds of success. — Scott Adams

The ability to expand your mind and strive for lifelong learning is more critical to your success than you think. Don't give up on lifelong learning.Ever. Research shows that it pays beyond the skills you acquire. More than ever before, a challenged, stimulated brain may well be the key to a vibrant later life.

Start spending time preparing for the future even when there are more important things to do in the present and even when there is no immediately apparent return to your efforts. Begin to plant seeds every day that will yield the best and most fulfilling life now and in the future.

These skills can radically improve your life. They may not seem earth shattering at first glance, but you'll be surprised at just how much they can affect your life and career now and for the rest of your productive life.

Mental Toughness

GRIT is that mix of passion, perseverance, and self-discipline that keeps us moving forward in spite of obstacles. — Daniel Coyle

The only person that can really push you a little bit further in life is yourself.Grit is both a trait and a skill. And the good new is, you can cultivate or better still grow your grit to strive for what means a lot to you. It's a skill that can be learned and practiced over time.

Grit is associated with perseverance, resilience, ambition, and the need for achievement. It involves maintaining goal focused effort for extended periods of time.

You can develop your capacity for grit. Your response to a challenging situation is more important the obstacle you face. Ryan Holiday says “obstacle is the way”. And you need grit to push through the obstacle every time you face a challenge.

Skill is the unified force of experience, intellect and passion in their operation. — John Ruskin

The ability to stick with and pursue a goal over a long period is an important indicator of achieving anything worthwhile in life. Grit is a better indicator of success than talent. No matter how talented you think you are, if you don’t put in the work, it will amount to nothing.

Adaptability

It is not the strongest of the species that survives, nor the most intelligent that survives. It is the one that is the most adaptable to change. — Charles Darwin

We live in ever-changing world which is unlikely to ever slow down. So, what mattered yesterday (e.g. skill, knowledge, social circle, etc.) very much so might not be worth a dime tomorrow. Change used to be slow and incremental: now it is rapid, radical and unpredictable.

Adaptability enables us to dwell on new circumstances and stay on top of the situation. Of course, this skill is best when combined with insight, giving us fresh perspective before the change itself. Growth depends on how adaptable you are. To stay relevant, most companies will need people who can change with time.

Silencing your inner critic

"Turn down the volume of your negative inner voice and create a nurturing inner voice to take it's place. When you make a mistake, forgive yourself, learn from it, and move on instead of obsessing about it. Equally important, don't allow anyone else to dwell on your mistakes or shortcomings or to expect perfection from you." — Beverly Engel

According to research by psychologist Ethan Kross, there's more to the idea of "your best self" than life affirmations spoken to your reflection in a mirror.

Your best shot at winning against your inner voice is to dare yourself. Start trying, creating, making something you are afraid to do. Don't stop trying, and your inner critic will be proven wrong.

You can't give in to the voice that wants to shut you down. You can't give up on yourself. When you fail to identify and separate yourself from this inner critic, you allow it to impact your behavior and shape the direction of your live.

Stop looking for what's wrong about you and everything you want to pursue, and see what's right about you instead! Focus more on what could go right instead of wrong. When you catch yourself criticising, stop and be realistic about what can actually happen when you concentrate on getting stuff done instead of thinking about them.

Learning to say "NO"

*Stop saying yes to sh*t you hate. Life's too short to say yes to things, activities, events, and tasks you hate.*

Saying YES drives most people insane, but they don't know how to say NO.Stop telling yourself you can't help it. Yes, you can. Stop wasting your time and energy. Especially if you work for yourself. You always have a choice.Choose your work and projects

cautiously. Of course, It's not always easy to know if the activity or task in question is worthy of a yes.

If what you are accepting to do won't improve, enhance or make you a better person, just say NO and focus on projects that are mutually beneficial to youand the other party. Find tasks that energize you and light you up, and say yes to those instead. You will be a happy and better person in the end.

Critical thinking

"Critical thinking is a desire to seek, patience to doubt, fondness to meditate, slowness to assert, readiness to consider, carefulness to dispose and set in order; and hatred for every kind of imposture." — Francis Bacon (1605)

The ability to actively and skillfully conceptualize, apply, analyse, synthesise, and/or evaluate information gathered from, or generated by, observation, experience, reflection, reasoning, or communication, is of immense importance to work.

It will continue to be a huge asset to your employer. They are desirable skills you should develop. Decision making and problem solving require gathering reliable information, evaluating the information for a variety of solutions and selecting the most appropriate option based on the criteria and situation.

People who can look at problems from a different angle often end up solving them in completely unexpected, often elegant ways. At the same time, they expose how narrowly the majority had viewed the problem, or whether it even was a problem.

Creative thinkers are innovative and inventive and are more likely to devise new ways of doing things that add value to the work environment, making systems and

procedures more efficient. Creative thinkers can offer new perspectives about the job and the company. And they will be indispensable in the near future.

Emotional intelligence

Emotional intelligence (EI) plays a role in everything. Highly emotionally intelligent people rank high on responsiveness, empathy, listening, and self-awareness. And they excel at interpersonal interaction.

The reason emotional intelligence is so widely valued is pretty simple: "It plays a role in everything," A.J. Marsden, a professor of psychology at Beacon College, tells Fast Company, like "task performance, contextual performance, interactions with customers and peers" — the list goes on.

People skills are so important now and will continue to be in high demand in the future. EI allows us to create relationships with others, provides insights into people's motives and allows us to predict responses.

Any discipline that benefits from the emotional intelligence that only humans can provide will be in high demand. If you are not a people's person, it's not too late. You can still learn how to better relate with others. You will need soft skills to thrive in the future.

The Doing Mindset > The Thinking Mindset

There are risks and costs to a program of action. But they are far less than the long-range risks and costs of comfortable inaction. — John F. Kennedy

Balancing thought and action will always be a challenge for many people.How much time should you spend thinking vs. doing?

With respect to goals, projects, and other to-do items, it's easy to get stuck too long in the thinking and planning phase. Many people get excited about a lot of ideas. But unfortunately they easily begin pushing them further back on their to-do lists, if not completely disregarding them as being unfeasible or unrealistic.

When you value "the thinking mindset" more than "the doing mindset" you will eventually end up with a note app or notebook full of dozens or even hundreds of ideas and plans. Greater percentage of them will never be done.And you will most likely not think about a lot of them again. Some are maybe 5–10% complete, and a few maybe at least 50% done. It can quickly turn into inaction habit.

Results come to those who "act" while others are discovering the "right" ways to generate results.

It's what you Do that defines you

"Do you want to know who you are? Don't ask. Act! Action will delineate and define you." — Thomas Jefferson

Do what you should. Don't talk about what you should be doing.

Being a Doer instead of just a Thinker requires an insane amount of discipline and commitment. Doing involves risk but it's the only way to make progress.

If you are not daring and focused enough, you can never get past the "thinking" stage of getting work done. Stop thinking you are at a disadvantage because of your weaknesses. If you really need to get something done, you will find a good reason why

you have to pursue it otherwise your excuses will constantly convince you why it can't be done.

Embrace the action habit!

"Small deeds done are better than great deeds planned. "— Peter Marshall

Don't over-plan and under-act!

Thinking and planning in advance is important, vital in fact, to your success but acting is even more crucial to long-term achievement.

Actions you take beat life-changing intentions. Not doing anything is the same as intending to do something but never actually doing it.

Does it really matter if you *wanted* or *really intended* to do something, but ended up just not doing it?

Just thinking about something won't do you any good if you don't actually do it. Every time you put something off, it's put into a queue, and nearly everything in that order of things to do may NEVER get done.

You can never get real progress if you don't take action. All of the self-help articles in the world can't save you if you never take action. Every time you read a book or article like this, immediately apply something from it (no matter how big or small).

Thinking about doing is more exhausting than doing.

Actually, holding onto too many things to do without necessarily getting them done or taken action makes you anxious and stressed. The constant reminder that you have something to start doesn't help your wellbeing. Most things on your to-do list won't be done. Take them off your list or maintain the healthy habit of doing something about them everyday. Being overwhelmed with many things to do and no sense of priority (no deadlines) usually means nothing will get done.

What You DO Matters!

Inaction breeds doubt and fear. Action breeds confidence and courage. If you want to conquer fear, do not sit home and think about it. Go out and get busy. — Dale Carnegie

What can I do right now to take even the smallest step towards achieving my most important goal on my to-do list?

As you think about this question, hold the expectation that the answer will be something simple that can be done in the next 30 minutes or less.Whatever reasonable answer pops into your head, accept it and act on it immediately.

Get that simple task done as quickly as you can. Sometimes you'll flow effortlessly into another task. And you will experience the "first action effect" that makes it easy to stay productive. It may take a little practice to use this strategy to consistently take action. But the benefits are enormous. Once you commit to getting started, momentum carries you. Producing results builds positive momentum. With momentum you'll get ahead and make progress much faster.

Not only is *doing* easier than *thinking about doing,* but *doing* also gives you the ability to check something off your to-do list, giving you a sense of progress, engagement, fulfillment, and accomplishment.

These Habits Will Immediately Improve How You Work

All human actions have one or more of these seven causes: chance, nature, compulsions, habit, reason, passion, desire." — Aristotle

Habits create routine, and most of us run our lives by some sort of routine. Habits define who we are, what we do and what we get to accomplish in life and career. Maybe what you always set you to accomplish daily, weekly or monthly is a crucial to your business or career: or maybe it isn't, but it has to be done anyway.

The important thing is that there is always a better or better still a smarter way to get things things. You should be getting the best return on your time and resources. Everyone wants to to do their daily tasks faster and better without wasting too much time. The good news is: there are always smarter ways to accomplish more for less. Here is what you can do to be better and smarter at what you do at work.

"For the past 33 years, I have looked in the mirror every morning and asked myself: 'If today were the last day of my life, would I want to do what I am about to do today?' And whenever the answer has been 'No' for too many days in a row, I know I need to change something." — Steve Jobs

Working better, not harder can and probably will make you healthier and happier. Working longer does not guarantee financial security, it's a stressful way to live with consequences. You could do better or better still work shorter but still be productive. Bertrand Russell, the English philosopher, was not a fan of work. In his 1932 essay,

“In Praise of Idleness”, he reckoned that if society were better managed the average person would only need to work four hours a day. Such a small working day would “entitle a man to the necessities and elementary comforts of life. In the morning you have the best chance to complete your task faster and better. Just get something done and tick it off the to-do list for the day.

“How you begin your morning often sets the tone and your attitude for the day.It can also derail or direct your focus. If you remain committed to good morning work habits, you won’t fall prey to feeling unproductive and distracted at the end of the day or week.” says Lynn Taylor, a workplace expert and author of Tame Your Terrible Office Tyrant; How to Manage Childish Boss Behavior and Thrive in Your Job.

Every given day, most people have one major to-do that’s highest priority. But when you’ve got the whole day stretching out ahead of you, it’s easy to put it off until after you get your coffee, check our email, or go to that meeting. According to Mark Twain, you should “Eat a live frog first thing in the morning and nothing worse will happen to you the rest of the day.”

Author Brian Tracy calls this “eating your frog,” quoting Mark Twain. He recommends that you complete the most unwanted task (task you’re most likely to procrastinate) you can think of for that day (= the frog). Define the task in the evening of the previous day.

Start off each day with the seemingly difficult tasks and wind down with less stressful tasks to close the day. I like the feeling of crossing things off. It makes me feel productive, so I have a to-do list and I cross them off each day.

“Challenge yourself with something you know you could never do, and what you’ll find is that you can overcome anything” — Anonymous.

Consistent productivity will even make you more productive with a positive sense of accomplishment. Increase the pace, not the hours at which you work and maintain that momentum until you get things done.

Start small. The smaller the better, because habit change is difficult, and trying to take on too much is a recipe for disaster. Want to exercise? Start with just 5–10 minutes. Want to wake up earlier? Try just 10 minutes earlier for now. Or consider half habits. Write it down. Just saying you’re going to change the habit is not enough of a commitment. You need to actually write it down, on paper. Write what habit you’re going to change.

“Your net worth to the world is usually determined by what remains after your bad habits are subtracted from your good ones.” — Benjamin Franklin

If you want to get one thing done at work today, get it on paper. Better still, write it on a sticky note and and place it where you can see it, to remind you of the task.
J.T. O’Donnell, Founder & CEO of CAREEREALISM.com and a LinkedIn influencer recommends the following from his 10 Things To Do Every Workday post.

1. Read something related to your industry.
2. Check in with each team member on their progress.
3. Review your top three goals for your company that are focused on its growth.
4. Identify and execute one task to support each of your top three goals.
5. Post five valuable pieces of content on all my major social media accounts.

Progress is the ultimate motivator. Know your motivations, and be sure they’re strong. Write them down in your plan. You have to be very clear why you’re doing this, and the

benefits of doing it need to be clear in your head. Set up public accountability. Blog about it, post on a forum, email your commitment and daily progress to friend or co-worker, post a chart up at your office. When we make it public — not just the commitment but the progress updates — we don't want to fail.

Don't set yourself up for failure. Take a few minutes break: Get up, go for a walk or do something completely different to recharge. Work in possibly 90 minute blocks with 10 minute intervals to recover and refuel. Stop looking for a perfect time. Are you waiting for a perfect time to do that task or start that project? There can never be a best time to do anything. The perfect time is now. You may have convinced yourself that now is not the best time because of X, Y, Z reasons.

But come tomorrow, you will still give yourself another excuse. Just get on with it. Re-clarify your goals (get rid of your fuzzy goals). What exactly do you want to achieve? What should you do to get there? What are the steps to take? Does your current work align with that? If not, what can you do about it?

According to Jim Stone (Personal Productivity Consultant, Developer, Philosopher), when you have fuzzy goals, you are likely to think things like this:
1. "Why am I doing this project?"
2. "What should the final product look like?"
3. "How will people actually benefit from this?"
4. "Should I work on this now, or is something else more important?

Some of his strategies for dealing with fuzzy goals
1. Ask yourself why you're doing the project. When you do this, you will come up with some purpose.Then ask yourself why you're pursuing that purpose. And keep doing that until your project is set within the context of your whole life.

2. After all this, it might turn out you don't have a good reason to work on this project, and that you need to work on another project.
3. Work out the relative importance of all your projects, so you can make sure you're working on your most important project.

Measurement can improve how you work. Take time to analyze how you work and how productive your strategies have been over the week. Can you do better in less hours. What is not working and why is it not working? What are you doing wrong? Do more of what works and less of what steals your time. Reward yourself when you achieve your task as scheduled.

Say no to extra commitments. Identify what's important to you every day or week, along with the "perfect day". Once you know what to focus on to be productive, you need to start saying "No" to things that aren't on your important list, and that are standing in the way of the perfect day. It just takes a call or email, but it's one of the most difficult things for a lot people.

The First 90 Minutes Rule

You are most productive in the morning. You're fresh and focused in the morning, even if you don't feel it. Your best work happens within a short time span of the day. And you should be making the most of it. Your productive morning should be spent on outputs, not inputs. It pays to protect your morning. Don't spend it distractions. Don't even think about scheduling a meeting at a time when people want to get most work done.Don't expect to generate enthusiasm at a morning meeting.

The basic principle of the first 90 minutes rule is to start your day by spending the first 90 minutes on your most important task.

The human body operates on cycles called “ultradian rhythms.” According to research, during each of these cycles, there is a peak when we are most energized and a period when we are exhausted. You are most active in the morning. Do your best work in whilst you have willpower and energy at its peak.

In a post on Zapier, Stephen Altrogge says:

“With the 90-minute focus technique, you take full advantage of the energy peaks and troughs that occur throughout your day: Work 90 minutes and then rest for 20–30 minutes. In discussing peak performance in a 1993 study, Anders Ericcson pointed out that those rest periods between intense work sessions is essential for improvement.”

What is the one most important thing you have to do every work day?
Once you identify that, preferably the night before, or better at the end of your day, write it down. And focus your energy on getting it accomplished the next morning once you are ready to begin your day.
There are hundreds of things you could choose to do in the morning. Completing your most important task not only moves it out of your way, but it gives you great energy because you get the feeling you’ve accomplished something worthwhile.

Make no room for distractions. Disengage: zero push notifications. Make your phone calls in the afternoon. This help you focus. Instead of responding to requests which hijack your focus and put you in a reactive mode, where other people’s priorities take center stage, take control of your morning.

There’re a million different ways a morning could go but if you observe the first 90 minites rule, you can do a lot more than you can imagine on any given work day. It doesn’t have to be the first thing you do when you wake up or get to the office but the 90 minutes period of work should be done before midday.

While there's probably not an ideal morning routine that fits everyone, you can learn a lot from the morning routines of successful people, research and inspiration behind starting your morning on the right foot. A focused work rule is also important. So spend the rest of your day by working intensely for 60 to 90 minutes. Take a 10 minute break after that to refresh your mind. Listen to some music, have a walk if you can, have a quick chat, and in 10 minutes you'll be ready to dive in again.

Establish a routine once you know your peak time.
Peak performance is dependent on passion, grit, determination, and a willingness to do something poorly until you can do it well. — Zig Ziglar

Starting and maintaining a positive daily morning routine is an investment and a way to do your best work everyday. It also gives you structure, building forward-moving habits, and creating momentum for the rest of the day. It helps you establish priorities, limit procrastination, keep track of your goals.
In the words of Lynn Taylor, a national workplace expert and author of Tame Your Terrible Office Tyrant; How to Manage Childish Boss Behavior and Thrive in Your Job.

"How you begin your morning often sets the tone and your attitude for the day.It can also derail or direct your focus. If you remain committed to good morning work habits, you won't fall prey to feeling unproductive and distracted at the end of the day or week."

Once you establish a routine, it ceases to be a struggle to get in productivity mode everyday because the habit becomes part of you. Tynan, the author of Superhuman by Habit, says, habits are "action[s] that you take on a repeated basis with little or no required effort or thought."

Many people pay little attention to the natural rhythms of their body. But once you know what times in the morning you can work better, use it your advantage and your body can deliver at its peak.

Working in 90-minute bursts first thing in the morning allows you to correlate your maximum energy levels with your most important task, which then gives your productivity a major boost. It's only when you come to appreciate and accept the ebbs and flows of your body that you can really start to deliver maximum results.
It's important you have a morning routine that sets you up for success.

Harsh Truths About Getting Things Done

Humans are prolific procrastinators. People have struggled with habitual hesitation going back to ancient civilizations. It's easy to make plans and throw dates on your calendar, and yet it's practically inevitable that you'll let some deadlines fly whilst you still have some tasks unfinished.

Everyone strives to do better every day. But the harsh reality is that until you are 100% committed to doing actual work, nothing else matters. Your fancy goals and weekly to-do lists won't help you if you can't commit to doing them.

People have the mental capacities to make ambitious plans, yet almost no time at all to put them into practice. It's easier to plan but a lot more difficult to do something about those plans. No webinar, no online course, no ebook, no mentorship will help you if you do not go all in and get things done and actually check them off your to-do list.

Confused, lost and uncertain? You are not alone. Feeling under pressure to deliver? It's the same old problems for everyone. Sometimes you lose control. There are many occasions when you feel uncomfortable and unfulfilled because of your inactions. Many people who hear or read what productivity hacks and strategies won't do anything with the information. They go back to their lives, don't change anything and get the same results they were getting before: not getting stuff done.

Your actions define you, not your thoughts
"Action is the foundational key to all success." –Pablo Picasso

Don't spend all your time thinking about everything you can make better or do. Conceptualizing a better world won't help you make progress. Until you start doing what needs to be done, you're not actually making a difference.

Good intention is a great thing but it counts for nothing if you don't take action. Action begets results. Results is what you want not ideas. You are judged by your outputs, not your thoughts. It pays to take real action in the direction of your goals.

Getting started is the biggest hurdle!
"To think is easy. To act is difficult. To act as one thinks is the most difficult." — Johann Wolfgang Von Goeth

The biggest hurdle for many of us is simply getting started. Making that important decision to take a step. You can be as big and successful as you can possibly imagine if you build that mindset you need to push yourself to make that all important decision to just start. You have everything you need to make an impact in the world if you can get past the many reasons why should postpone that task. Don't think too far into the future. Use what you have right now at where you are and witness the magic of getting things done.

You will never be able to do it all

Success demands a singleness of purpose. — Vince Lombardi

Do one thing well, not three things badly! Many people want do well at work. And make the most of their skills. It's incredible what you risk and do to progress. But sometimes you will have nothing to show for it. What you choose to do may be good use of your time but you probably won't be able to show real results. You won't be able to do everything this week or this month. And that's okay.As long as you are consistent and stick to the process. Sometimes priorities change. That's part of the journey. It's better to be clear about what you want to get done at any moment in time than combining multiple tasks.

It's so easy to get seduced into the importance of a task, project or job and drive yourself insane to over deliver or impress. But it's always important to take time out and ask: What am I risking or taking for granted? What could I have done different to achieve the same results? At the end of the day, is that the best use of my time?

Distraction is the enemy!

"If you see distraction externally, you end up creating an internally distracted state." — Tim Ferriss

Demand for our time is increasingly exceeding our capacity — draining us of the energy we need to bring our skill and talent fully to life. We are currently exposed to an unprecedented flood of information and requests than ever before. And we feel compelled to read and respond at all hours of the day and night. Being selective, doing less, is the path of the productive. It pays to focus on the important few and ignore the rest.

"The net is designed to be an interruption system, a machine geared to dividing attention," Nicholas Carr explains in his book "The Shallows: What the Internet Is Doing to Our Brains." "We willingly accept the loss of concentration and focus, the division of our attention and the fragmentation of our thoughts, in return for the wealth of compelling or at least diverting information we receive."

There is no perfect time!
"Do not wait: the time will never be 'just right'. Start where you stand, and work with whatever tools you may have at your command and better tools will be found as you go along." — Napoleon Hill

Stop looking for a perfect time to start work. Are you waiting for a perfect time to do that task or start that project? There can never be a best time to do anything. The perfect time is now. You may have convinced yourself that now is not the best time because of X, Y, Z reasons.

But come tomorrow, you will still give yourself another excuse. Just get on with it. Re-clarify your goals (get rid of your fuzzy goals). What exactly do you want to achieve? What should you do to get there? What are the steps to take? Does your current work align with that? If not, what can you do about it?

Sometimes the best thing to do is: nothing
"Reflect on what you do in a day. You may have never realised how some simple harmless activities rob you of precious time." — Vivek Naik

Life is a challenge. Sometimes it's common to feel like you're constantly working against the clock every day, and moving plans and tasks around to meet deadlines. And guess what, when you do take time to relax ... you feel guilty. But you shouldn't.

Many productivity resources are focused on what you can do MORE of in order to achieve your goals. But MORE is hard to achieve. Many people can't get a lot done. And they get anxious and stressed even more.

Doing nothing refreshes your mind. Taking breaks in our mental work is equally helpful. Brief diversions improve focus, according to research. Taking a break allows you to come back to your task with renewed energy and sense of purpose.
The next time you feel guilty about doing nothing, consider how much more effective it may make you in the long run.

The Pomodoro Technique to 10x Results

It's getting increasingly impossible to have a perfect working environment.However, you can work smarter without having to work harder. Time is not your enemy. If you can master it and know when to do what, you won't have to race the clock to finish tasks, projects and meet deadlines.

Have you thought about breaking your most difficult work into simple time-bound tasks?

Enter The Pomodoro

The Pomodoro technique teaches us to work with time, instead of struggling against it. It can help you power through distractions and get things done in short bursts.

The Pomodoro Technique, strictly about time-management was developed by Italian entrepreneur Francesco Cirillo. He created this simple study habit (when he was still a

college student in the late 1980s) to maximize his productivity and reduce a feeling of burnout.

It focuses on working in short, intensely focused bursts, and then giving yourself a brief break to recover and start over.

The technique requires a timer, and it allows you to break down your large complex task into manageable intervals. Once you break your work into focused time blocks, you can manage it for the rest of time allocated for it.

Sean Kennedy, a writer at Zapier says:

The benefits of the Pomodoro Technique come from the frequent breaks, which help your mind stay fresh. The focused time blocks also force you to adhere to fixed limits, so you'll be encouraged to complete a task more quickly, or in the case of a large task, spread it out over a number pomodoros.

There are even apps specifically designed to help you use the Pomodoros technique effectively. Focus Booster, PomoDone, Pomodoro Keeper, Tomighty, Pomodoro.cc and Pomodoro Time Pro are six of the best apps you can use to help you stay focused when you start using the Pomodoro Technique.

Paul Klipp, president of Lunar Logic's Polish branch, explains on Quora that the Pomodoros technique works best for his schedule.

"At the core of this approach is the value of focusing for short bursts of activity. Specifically, one chooses a task (or set of tasks) to be completed in 25 minutes, sets a timer for 25 minutes, closes the door, unplugs the phone, turns off IM notifications

and closes their email software, and works, diligently, on only the task at hand, for 25 minutes. Then you can take a 5 minute break."

You might think that a person could do 16 of these cycles in a day. I'm lucky to get more than two in a day without interruptions. But in those 50 minutes I get more done than I do in the other seven hours of my work day, at least in terms of advancing the most important aspects of my most important projects."

Here's how the Pomodoro Technique works, courtesy Cirillo Company

1. CHOOSE A TASK YOU'D LIKE TO GET DONE

Something big, something small, something you've been putting off for a million years: it doesn't matter. What matters is that it's something that deserves your full, undivided attention.

2. SET THE POMODORO FOR 25 MINUTES

Make a small oath to yourself: I will spend 25 minutes on this task and I will not interrupt myself. You can do it! After all, it's just 25 minutes.

3. WORK ON THE TASK UNTIL THE POMODORO RINGS

Immerse yourself in the task for the next 25 minutes. If you suddenly realize you have something else you need to do, write the task down on a sheet of paper.

4. WHEN THE POMODORO RINGS, PUT A CHECKMARK ON A PAPER

Congratulations! You've spent an entire, interruption-less Pomodoro on a task.

5. TAKE A SHORT BREAK

Breathe, meditate, grab a cup of coffee, go for a short walk or do something else relaxing (i.e., not work-related). Your brain will thank you later.

6. EVERY 4 POMODOROS, TAKE A LONGER BREAK

Once you've completed four pomodoros, you can take a longer break. 20 minutes is good. Or 30. Your brain will use this time to assimilate new information and rest before the next round of Pomodoros.

It's important to note that a pomodoro is an indivisible unit of work. If you tend to get interrupted with emails, notifications, or other distractions that can't be helped, you may have some difficulties using this technique. You probably won't benefit from this technique. But you can still experiment and find out how you could use it for some of your most difficult tasks that need little or no interruption.

The Cross Calendar Approach to Building Consistent Habits (Seinfeld Strategy)

I never could have done what I have done without the habits of punctuality, order, and diligence, without the determination to concentrate myself on one subject at a time. — Charles Dickens

Building great and consistent habits is difficult. Breaking bad habits and sticking to new good ones over a long period of time can be insanely hard. It's easy to get motivated but it's hard to stay disciplined. Jim Rohn once said"motivation is what gets you started, habit is what keeps you going".

If you're trying to build a new habit, chances are you're going to break it. Most of the time, "getting started is the hardest part". And staying consistent is even more harder. A significant part of habit formation is having the mental energy needed to actually commit to the new habit.

This strategy was once known as the “Seinfeld Strategy”. But Jerry Seinfeld has openly said on Reddit that he didn’t come up with this idea. Regardless, it’s still a great way to stay disciplined and committed when you start a new habit.

The simple cross calendar approach:

1. Get a big wall calendar that has a whole year on one page and hang it on a prominent wall. If a whole year calendar is too much to handle on your wall, stick to the monthly calendar. And get yourself a red marker.
2. Choose your habit, starting today. To achieve consistency, choose a habit that’s really easy to start. Focus on an easy start and pick up the intensity as you progress.
3. For each day you write even half a page of your next ebook, make even the smallest progress on your passion project, eat something healthy, read 2 pages of your favourite book, or do something insignificant to advance your meaningful work, you get to put a big red X over that day. You don’t have to join a gym yet if you want to exercise. Or change your entire diet at the very beginning. You can start with something small. Micro steps. Small wins will keep you going. That way you can actually do something.
4. After a few days, you would have built a consistent chain. Just keep at it and the chain will grow longer every day. When you get a few weeks under your belt, it will feel good, especially if you stay consistent. Your only job is to not break the chain.

To maintain the consistency you expect: Choose tasks that are simple to maintain and capable of producing the outcome you want!

Don’t break the chain, and you will build consistent routines that helps you achieve your long-term goals. Whatever they may be. You will probably have a couple of false

starts but don't let that get the best of you. Sustained effort over time makes the real difference.

Here is what James Clear (author and authority on personal development) says about the "Seinfeld Strategy":

Don't break the chain on your workouts and you'll find that you get fit rather quickly. Don't break the chain in your business and you'll find that results come much faster. Don't break the chain in your artistic pursuits and you'll find that you will produce creative work on a regular basis.

So often, we assume that excellence requires a monumental effort and that our lofty goals demand incredible doses of willpower and motivation. But really, all we need is dedication to small, manageable tasks. Mastery follows consistency.

The idea of the cross calender approach to building consistent habits is to prove to yourself that you can stick to something small for the next 30 or more days. Once you are on a roll, mastered the chain and remaining consistent over time without a break, you can start increasing the difficulty.

Don't aim for performance in the beginning. Focus on sticking to the chain.That's why picking something easy helps. Because you can get it done without breaking a sweat. Doing something impressive once or twice won't matter if you never stick with it for the long-run.

Micro gains, small wins. That's the goal.

Productivity Techniques for Peak Performance

The never-ending search for better and smarter ways to be awesome at what we do never ends. Your quest to make significant progress everyday can be achieved with some of these productive techniques.

1. Do it first. In Zen To Done Leo suggests picking your 3 Most Important Tasks (MITs) and doing them first thing in the morning. Similarly, once you find what truly matters, try to take care of it first before spending time on tasks that matter less to you. Some people have experienced significant increases in productivity when writing, working out, or meditating early in the morning.

"Perform the dreaded task now and the unpleasant activity is soon over. Delay action will nag at you infinitely." — Anonymous

2. Peak times. Identify your peak cycles of productivity, and schedule your most important tasks for those times. Work on minor tasks during your non-peak times. It's important to organize your day around your body's natural rhythms, says Carson Tate, founder and managing partner of management consultancy, Working Simply. Tackle complex tasks when your energy's at its highest level.

3. Recognizing the difference between importance and urgency is crucial. What is important today may be urgent tomorrow. It's your job to know what is urgent and needs immediate attention and what is important that can be put off until tomorrow. When your tasks are separated into important and urgent, you are more likely to give attention to them and get them done as soon as possible. Don't be afraid to have someone take a message, or to answer that e-mail tomorrow, so you can concentrate on your tasks.

4. Single-task. Stop multi-tasking, at least not on a day-to-day basis. Instead, focus on one task at a time. This leads to greater productivity and less stress.

“Think of many things; do one.” — Portuguese proverb

Multitasking doesn’t work. Researchers believe that the human brain only has so much processing capacity — so in trying to carry out several different tasks at once, you’re creating a bottleneck, rather than maximizing your efficiency.

5. Don’t plan meetings that require more than thirty minutes to complete. Seriously, cut out all the unnecessary meetings. If you do have a crucial meeting in mind that requires a long time-span, it’s better to split the meeting into two or more parts.

6. Monitor existing improvement strategies. What strategies have worked in the past for you? How did you achieve goals yesterday? What is currently working and what is not working?

If you start, you’ve already made a big step towards finishing. Stick with what works and do more of what makes you happy and productive. Monitor what you do on a daily basis for about 1 week.

7. Create and publicize short-term wins. Share your success stories with your team. As the little victories occur, make sure that they are communicated and celebrated. Once you team realize their efforts are paying off and are being achieved, it gets easier for everybody to work towards the common goal.

8. Get uncomfortable at least 1x per day (ideally 3x or 5x). By “get uncomfortable” I mean “summon the courage to do something that makes you anxious”. Speak up during the work conference call. Say hi to the pretty girl or fella standing next to you in line. Run 4 miles instead of 3. Et cetera. Go the extra mile. Remember: “Everything you’ve ever wanted is on the other side of fear.” — George Addair

9. Before your sit to work, remind yourself of the ONE thing you need to get done today. There are high chances you will get more important things done this way.

10. Plan your tomorrow, today. This is no new knowledge. Almost all the productivity content you would read on the internet talks about planning your day ahead.

“What you do TODAY can improve all your tomorrows.” — Anonymous

Managing time is an art and only a few people know how to do it. And, a majority of those who do it exercise a better control on their lives. You feel empowered and confident when you know in advance what to do today?

11. Get your priorities right. Put first things first. What is the most important thing you need done in the month, week or day. Start writing things down to remind yourself of the urgent tasks that need your attention.

Both what needs doing and what has been accomplished. Separate urgent and most important tasks from non-urgent ones. Set time bound and measurable goals.
12. Focus on what you can control. You may not have control over a lot of things that take up most of your working hours. But the good new is, you can focus your time and attention on things you can control. That’s where you can find your balance.

Many business leaders will tell you that work/life balance is a myth and can’t deliberately be achieved. But guess what, you can make deliberate choices about which opportunities you will pursue and which ones you will decline. That way you can engage meaningfully with work, life and even family and be better at it every month.

13. Stay in the moment. If you feel overwhelmed (like pretty much everyone), it might not be because you have so much to do, but rather that you are trying to do too much at the same time, says Douglas Merrill founder of ZestFinance.

14. Don't reply on your memory. Our memory sucks. You won't remember to get all those tasks done. Write it down or use an app. There hundreds of productivity apps out there. You can use your them to dictate reminders, events, and tasks that need to be done as you think about them throughout the day.

15. Nothing beats good old planning and sticking to a schedule.
If you know what needs to be done today and tomorrow, you are more likely to see it through and get it done. Executing an action plan is easier if you constantly revisit your plan and remind yourself of the deadline. Knowing why you are doing something and how it ties back to your long-range goals is crucial.

What if you write "Get X, Y and Z done today" and stick it where you can constantly see it. If your tasks are too intimidating in size, break them down into tiny chunks and get them done one after the other.
Discipline is the key. Be your own watcher when it comes to keeping track of time spent for each task. Don't put something off if you can finish it now and get it off of your plate.

16. Find your flow. This is actually two steps grouped into one. First, you'll want to find a time that's quiet, or you'll never be able to focus. For me, that's mornings, before the hustle of everyday life builds to a dull roar. That might be early morning, when you just wake, or early in the work day, when most people haven't arrived yet or are still getting their coffee and settling down.

Or you might try the lunch hour, when people are usually out of the office. Evenings work well too for many people. Or, if you're lucky, you can do it at any time of the day if you can find a quiet spot to work in. Whatever time you choose, it should also be a peak energy time for you. Some people get tired after lunch — that's not a good time to go for Flow. Find a time when you have lots of energy and can concentrate.

17. Finally, don't overload yourself! People tend to pile too much on themselves for a single day, overestimating how much they can actually do. Believe it or not, a break is actually the best way to keep your mind focused. The brain can only concentrate for so long before it switches off entirely. It's why at the end of a Friday afternoon your motivation to continue working slows to a crawl.

Every person has a limit. Extend this limit by taking a short ten or twenty-minute break every few hours. Your boss might think you're lazy, but they'll soon see you can stay fresher for longer. You have to make a little time to be refreshed every now and then. You are far more likely to succeed if you are having fun, so play just as hard as you work. Find time to laugh, whether it is catching up with friends, chatting to new people.

The One Thing That is a Better Indicator of Your Success Than Talent

The trait that takes you from average to spectacular is not your IQ! You are unique, and so is everyone else. Success means a lot to every person. It's a weighted combination of power, status, money, family, and work. You can define success in your own terms, because what brings you fulfillment and meaning is not the same for everyone.

People pursue success for different reasons. The fortunate few with a high IQ advantage may find it easy to pursue specific careers in life. And what could take you twice as long to learn and achieve will be an easy pursuit for them.

Deliberate practice, self-discipline, and perseverance have a lot more to do with your success than you think!
"I fear not the man who has practiced ten thousand kicks once, but I fear the man who has practiced one kick ten thousand times." — Bruce Lee

Talent is overrated. Thousands of hours of hard work can compensate for what you think is a weakness. You can master any skill if you put your mind to it and commit to relentless practice. Embracing repetition means changing your mindset; instead of viewing it as a chore, view it as your most powerful tool.

In Talent Is Overrated, Geoff Colvin argues that deliberate, methodical, and sustained practice is the way to achieve true mastery. "Deliberate practice is hard. It hurts. But it works. More of it equals better performance. Tons of it equals great performance," Colvin writes.

You could argue that a set of genes give rise to some particular skill and that Einstein had the physics gene and Mozart had the symphony gene. But guess what? Even those with some kind of talent have to work hard to reach the peak of their selected careers. Einstein and Mozart had to work damn hard to achieve greatness.

Mozart once wrote to a friend: "People err who think my art comes easily to me. I assure you, dear friend, nobody has devoted so much time and thought to composition as I. There is not a famous master whose music I have not industriously studied through many times."

You can easily attribute insane success to talent. But the ability to keep plugging away despite any setbacks or failures can significantly improve your odds of succeeding at any skill you choose to master.

Daniel Coyle, author of "The Little Book of Talent" explains:
"From a distance, top performers seem to live charmed, cushy lives. When you look closer, however, you'll find that they spend vast portions of their life intensively practicing their craft. Their mind-set is not entitled or arrogant; it's 100-percent blue collar: They get up in the morning and go to work every day, whether they feel like it or not."
Researcher Dr. K. Anders Ericsson of the University of Stockholm has found that talent is really about deliberate practice. The mix of passion, perseverance, and self-discipline that keeps you moving forward in spite of obstacles can contribute to your success more than your IQ. Your ability to stick with and pursue any goal over a long period of time is an important indicator of achieving anything worthwhile in your life and career.

In an article on LinkedIn, Daniel Goleman, the author of Focus: The Hidden Driver of Excellence, argues that the trait that takes you from average to spectacular comes from your measure of cognitive control, not your IQ. "The abilities that set stars apart from the average at work cover the emotional intelligence spectrum: self-awareness, self-management, empathy, and social effectiveness," says Daniel.

He references studies from the University of Pennsylvania to exemplify the importance of these skills: The students who earned the highest grades weren't necessarily the ones with the highest IQs, but rather those who kept trying despite setbacks and failures. These studies suggest that one of the most crucial skills you need to succeed is having a talent for working hard. The ability to persevere and maintain goal-focused effort for extended periods is important for your success.

The good news is, you can cultivate the perseverance and mental toughness success requires. Your response to a challenging situation is more important than the obstacles you face, hence the need to develop powerful motivation to help you achieve your goals. Tenacity matters more than talent.

The Art of Purposeful Practice (Not All Practice Makes Perfect)

"If we follow the mastery process long enough, inspired by a profound interest and curiosity we cannot fail to achieve something exceptional." — Robert Greene

Purposeful practice is serving the tennis ball 20, 35, or 50 times until the serve is "near perfect". It is working on a piano scales every day without fail until the fingering is so automatic, the fingers fly across the keys. It is committing to something so many times that it becomes a purposeful routine that gets you closer to mastery. You become so good, they can't ignore you. These practices, whether guided or independent, provides the kind of extended learning needed to hone your craft. It's the ultimate process that leads to mastery.

Purposeful practice demands focus and intense concentration on a skill, problem, or even a project beyond the ordinary. It is a long-term commitment with a single goal in mind. Every activity is strategically designed to purposefully improve performance. The difference between proficient and expert performances often depends on the amount and quality of practice.

Quantity > Quality...for beginners!
"Landing on your butt twenty thousand times is where great performance comes from" — Geoff Calvin

The extraordinary commitment of the young Mozart, under the guidance of his father produced one of the most prolific and influential composers of the classical era. Mozart had clocked up 3500 hours by the time he was 6 and had studied his chosen profession for 18 years before he wrote his Piano concerto No 9 at the age of 21. Top athletes don't become experts at what they do by simply practicing; they get there through purposeful practice.

The differences between expert performers, creatives, and normal professionals reflect a life-long persistence of deliberate, purposeful effort to improve performance. Tiger Woods started when he was 2 years old. Serena Williams started playing at 3, Venus Williams at 4. They committed to deep, sustained immersion in purposeful practice.

Uncommon achievement requires an uncommon level of grit and a massive amount of faith even when you keep failing. You need a deeper connection to stay on the same path for years.

Anyone can achieve mastery with purposeful practice. With considerable, specific, and sustained efforts over time, you can do most things you struggle with. You can only turn into the expert you want to become by deliberate, purposeful practice.
You've got to respect the process!

"There are really three parts to the creative process. First there is inspiration, then there is the execution, and finally there is the release." — Eddie Van Halen
The ability to show up everyday even when you are not motivated to learn, create, make something is the most valuable trait you need to be a professional. It doesn't come easy but it's a requirement to survive the process of creating or doing something unique and remarkable.

Mastering anything usually involves exploration, adjustment, and improvisation. You can't always know your destination in advance. And that's okay. But be prepared for constant average work to get better at mastering the skill you have chosen to master. Give yourself permission to screw up and move on when things don't go as plans.

You can't create a masterpiece without creative mess. Whatever you intend to master now or in the future, you need to prepare yourself for the long haul. And that means hundreds of thousands of hours will be spent making mistakes and starting over. And that's okay. One of the greatest impediments to creativity is impatience. It pays to value and embrace the creative process. It's the only way to master any skill.

Excellence comes from constantly stretching to reach a much higher goal
"Mediocrity will never do. You are capable of something better." — Gordon B.Hinckley
Purposeful practice builds new neural pathways. You can move the boundary of your comfort bubble to accommodate new routines that will contribute to your growth.

Anders Ericsson and Robert Pool explains:
"The most effective and most powerful types of practice in any field work by harnessing the adaptability of the human body and brain to create, step by step, the ability to do things that were previously not possible."

People who achieve extraordinary results put in a lot more hours to practice than the rest of us. But while their performances and what they do are remarkable, there is no mystery at all about how they developed them. They practiced. A lot. Beyond the ordinary. This increase in the amount and sophistication of practice resulted in a steady improvement over time. And even they become masters and experts, they don't stop practicing to deliver even amazing results expected of them.

Arsene Wenger (Manager at Arsenal Football Club) once said:

“To perform at your maximum, you have to teach yourself to believe with an intensity that goes way beyond logical justification. No top performer has lacked this capacity for irrational optimism.

Consistency and a series of purposeful actions will transform the way you work and hone in your chosen craft.

The “Do Something” Mindset (The Power of Practicing More)

“For the things we have to learn before we can do them, we learn by doing them.” — Aristotle

You alone have the power to close the the gap between where you are now and where you want to be. It’s a choice that comes with responsibility, sacrifice and a lot of grit. Nobody can push that further to do anything more than yourself. Your inner dialogue determines how you present yourself to the world around you and most importantly when you take the necessary steps to actually make a move in the direction of your dreams.

Rather than avoiding opportunities or convincing yourself that you can’t do something, say yes to more things. Yes to creating more. Yes to doing what really expect of yourself. Yes to progress. And yes to starting today, not tomorrow. You should also learn how to say “no” more often if agreeing to do too many things is one of your problems. You don’t win by sitting on the fence. You succeed by getting your hands dirty. There are no shortcuts to progress or mastery. You can never beat the process. But you can overcome the obstacles.

You want to start a business, get on with it. You want to make a significant move in your career. Make that move now! It’s never too late to make, create or do. The time has never been right. It never will. Action begets outcome. Outcome begets action.

Rinse, lather and repeat and you have momentum. You'll become unstoppable. Run, walk or crawl.Whatever you do, just move in the direction of your dreams.
You will be better than everyone else who isn't trying, moving or making progress. Everything else around you is moving. Nobody stops for you because you want to think things through. Don't overthink!

Knowledge does not necessarily drive results
"Whatever you dream you can do, begin it. Boldness has genius, power and magic in it. Begin it now." — Goethe

Many people are caught in the "knowledge trap". The pursuit of more facts, information, skills, experience, education or practical understanding of a subject before taking action. We often hide behind knowledge acquisition and use learning as an excuse to delay the more important choice of actually doing something or getting your hands dirty. You should be spending your time actively practicing.

James Clear explains:
"Passive learning is not a form of practice because although you gain new knowledge, you are not discovering how to apply that knowledge. Active practice, meanwhile, is one of the greatest forms of learning because the mistakes you make while practicing reveal important insights.

You need some level of knowledge to get started in any endeavour but you don't need all the information about your industry to do something about your chosen life's work. Nobody can ever be ready to do anything. Learning something new can actually be a waste of time if your goal is to make progress and not simply gain additional knowledge.

Choose to practice more

Practice puts brains in your muscles. — Sam Snead

You get better with practice. Almost nobody gets it right the first time, or the 21st, or the 41st time. Active practice creates skill. Overtime you improve and become a master of your craft.

"Everything in life worth achieving requires practice. In fact, life itself is nothing more than one long practice session, an endless effort of refining our motions.When the proper mechanics of practice are understood, the task of learning something new becomes a stress-free experience of joy and calmness, a process which settles all areas in your life and promotes proper perspective on all of life's difficulties." — Thomas Sterner, The Practicing Mind.

Practice done properly isn't drudgery on the way to mastery or a waste of your valuable time, especially if you are a beginner but a fulfilling process in and of itself.

Don't rush it. The almost inevitable desire to hurry up the process can impede your creativity. Give yourself permission to screw up in the process. It's okay to suck. You will get better with time. There are no shortcuts to mastery. Only smartcuts. Practice shifting your mind and energy towards both focusing on and finding joy in the process of "achieving" instead of having the goal itself. Once you master this skill, the practice and the act of doing something becomes easy.It's incredibly fulfilling to know that you are actually getting stuff done, no matter how slow you move.

The Price of Success

The important thing is this: to be ready at any moment to sacrifice what you are for what you could become. — Charles Dickens

Everything has a price. You can't have an amazing lifestyle without sacrificing something. Every successful person you know today has a "price" story to tell. There is no substitute for sacrifice when it comes to success. The price is the way.
A relentless obsession with achieving outrageous results has everything to do with your success. But there is a line you shouldn't cross on your way to the top. Your reputation, principles and integrity are of paramount importance. Don't do anything to jeopardize those.

Everybody wants to succeed at something. Whether it's in losing weight, learning a skill, starting a podcast, writing ebooks, or starting your life's work. For those who have tried and failed, success seems elusive. But it's not, if you can pick yourself up and try again. You can live the life you want, once you are willing to pay the price. With considerable, specific, and sustained efforts over time, you can do or have most things you want in life.

The rare people who do become truly exceptional at something do so not because they believe they're exceptional. On the contrary, they become amazing because they're obsessed with getting results. When you live for a strong purpose, then hard work isn't an option. It's a necessity.

Choose your suffering!
He who would accomplish little must sacrifice little; he who would achieve much must sacrifice much; he who would attain highly must sacrifice greatly. — James Allen

The extraordinary commitment of the young Mozart, under the guidance of his father produced one of the most prolific and influential composers of the classical era. Mozart had clocked up 3500 hours by the time he was 6 and had studied his chosen profession for 18 years before he wrote his Piano concerto No 9 at the age of 21.

We all have limited time and energy, but few of us ever become truly exceptional at more than one thing, if anything at all. Choose to pursue what brings out the best in you.

The cost of giving up is much more expensive than the price of long-term fulfilment. Doing nothing is not an option. Idleness will almost always lead to regret later. The secret to finding fulfilment, in general, is to do something of value to yourself and/or others regularly.

Comfort is the enemy!
One-half of knowing what you want is knowing what you must give up before you get it. — Sidney Howard

Misery is comfortable. It's why so many people prefer it. It's so much easier to just sit back and criticize other people's creations. Comfort kills potential.Your body and mind crave easy routines. We naturally gravitate towards our safe zones. But your growth depends on discomfort. To achieve greatness, you have to push past your safe zone.

Alan Henry of Lifehacker explains: *"The idea of the comfort zone goes back to a classic experiment in psychology. Back in 1908, psychologists Robert M. Yerkes and John D. Dodson explained that a state of relative comfort created a steady level of performance. In order to maximize performance, however, we need a state of relative anxiety — a space where our stress levels are slightly higher than normal.This space is called "Optimal Anxiety," and it's just outside our comfort zone.*

Left unchecked, we always default toward a more comfortable path. Your comfortable zone provides a state of mental security. You can understand why it's so hard to kick your brain out of your comfort zone. It pays to explore new routines, paths, ideas, disciplines and new ways that can help you get closer to your life's work and purpose.

Excellence comes from constantly stretching to reach a much higher goal!

Time, not money, is your most valuable asset
"A man who dares to waste one hour of time has not discovered the value of life." — Charles Darwin

To become truly great at something, you have to dedicate shit-tons of time and energy to it. People who achieve extraordinary results put in a lot more hours to practice than the rest of us. But while their performances and what they do are remarkable, there is no mystery at all about how they developed them. They practiced. A lot. Beyond the ordinary to get to where they want to be. They paid the price.

The results and success you want could take twice as long. Don't quit because you can't figure out the process. Don't quit because the price is too high. If you want it bad enough, you will find a way. Deliberate long practice has a lot to do with your success than you think.

The good news is that the sheer act of practicing more and making a commitment to your long-term goal will help you along the way. The bad news is that the obstacle or the price is the only way to the top. People quit because it takes too long to see results. If you stick to the process long enough, you will see results.

Benjamin Hardy, a prolific writer at Medium once said:
"Nothing in life is free, especially your time. Everything has a cost. And when it comes to your time, the cost is heavy. You can never get even one second back. You can live your life on purpose. You can spend your time on things you value. You can be who you intended to become. You can continue to progress and evolve, even after you've become successful and fulfilled. But the price must be payed."

Consistent hustle always wins. Stop looking for shortcuts.
The success everybody wants takes effort, time and lots of both hard and smart work. And there are no guarantees. Its full of risks. People who are comfortable hate risks. They choose stability over maximising their potential. And that can make you miserable. Don't choose to settle because of an expensive price.

In the real world, you don't get anything by wishing it, and you can't get a reaction without action. When you play it too safe, you're taking the biggest risk of your life. Invest your asset. There are 168 hours every week. Let that sink in for a moment. That is a monumental amount of time. Where could it possibly go?If you really want to do what have to do to make you a better person, you will find, create or make time for it. Nobody said it will be easy. But it's not impossible. The price of success is much lower than the price of failure. How much is success worth to you?

Overcoming Distraction

There are no shortcuts to mastering anything worthwhile. Only smartcuts.Almost everyone can sprint. The road to mastery requires consistency.Everything meaningful in life is a marathon. Invest your time in creating work that answers questions you're genuinely interested in.

"Pursue something because it fascinates you, because the pursuit itself engages and compels you."- Justine Musk

Why waste your time creating something you don't care about, aren't invested in? Life is too short. Perhaps it would be better to spend the little life you have on something that matters to you, that will matter to those you are creating for.

The road to greatness

Start by admitting that greatness doesn't come from the distraction and busywork that often fills up our lives. It comes from making a difference in the world. If you approach work with the mindset of "What can I offer?" instead of "What can I get?" you can alter the very substance of your engagement.

Now consider how you can make a difference in the lives of others. Consider your current work, which perhaps already makes a difference — how can you refocus yourself on this work? Or consider creating a side project, and carving out the time for this. It doesn't matter if you achieve the compassionate result you set out to achieve — what matters is the intention to improve the lives of others. You can't control the result, but you can control the intention.

Show up, every day

Showing up is not sufficient. Make an impact. Take every opportunity to show up but reset expectations. Leave a mark. Show your most amazing work. Carve out the time. Put aside everything else. Realize that this life is limited and precious and amazing, and you shouldn't waste a minute of it. Pursue this compassionate and genuine work with single-minded devotion.This one thing matters, and all else can be put aside for now, unless it's in support of your work.

Focus on weekly adaptations

Most people try to focus on something that will take a year to achieve, but you lose motivation, and what if things change during that year? Instead, focus on one week at a time. That's a doable chunk of time — you can do a week at a time, but you can't really do a year at a time. And each week, see how you can adapt what you're doing so that your method gets better and better over time. Review how you did, find the obstacles, and plan around them for the next week.

Work in smaller sprints

If you're going to work for a 4-hour block (for example), I recommend doing shorter sprints in this block, like 30 minutes each. This allows you to take breaks of about 5–10 minutes, and makes the 4 hours more doable.

Embrace the suck

You'll suck at most things in the beginning. It takes time, persistence, and patience to create your most amazing work. Keep on trying. "Embrace the suck" is a term often used in the military, and there's some truth to it — if you open your arms and welcome sucking at something, find curiosity about it, move closer to this feeling of sucking ... you can survive, and learn a lot. It's only when we can be OK with the suck, and stay with it, that we can make any progress. And eventually we'll get good at whatever we suck at, and we'll love being good at it. And then (this is a secret), you'll realize that being good at this thing is just another comfort zone. You'll want to push out of that, when you get there, and find a new way to suck. But you can worry about that later.

Fill your year with curiosity and a learning stance

Many people get discouraged if they fall off their goals or habits, but that's because they have an all-or-nothing mindset. They see failure as evidence that they can't do it. Far from it: failure is evidence that things need adjusting. It's a way to learn, so that you can get better.

Be curious about what will work for you, about what this new habit will be like (instead of having a preconceived idea), and about what happens when you make adjustments. See all your successes and failures as learning, not a sign that you are good or not good. With this flexible mindset, you'll be able to weather out any kinds of disruptions, missteps, obstacles or changes.

Share yourself Everyday

Show up everyday and work on your most important life work. Whether the outcome is magnificent or eternal, whether it changes people's lives, changes the world, changes you or groundbreaking, it matters that you show up. You can find motivation in the fact that you have a tribe waiting to hear from you. Waiting to know what you are currently working on.

Waiting to find out your next amazing steps that could change their lives. If you're willing to take the risk of sharing yourself and your ideas with the world, you can create value you will be proud of. To take your idea, business, or career, and turn it into something truly awesome.
Practice until you're amazing.

Motivate Yourself to Do (and Achieve) Anything With These Thoughts

Words have power — and the ones in this post are guaranteed to challenge the way you think and perhaps even change the way you live. They have inspired me to choose life, persevere and live life to the full. Don't give up on yourself just yet, your most amazing life is still ahead of you. Your very best work, project, experiences are in front of you, not behind you. Whether you feel stuck or just need a good dose of inspiration from great minds, these should do the trick.

1. You must have a compelling response for: why the hell am i doing this? -Elana Carter
2. Give yourself permission to think and act without approval. Choose to do your most amazing work without anyone's approval. Bet on yourself!
3. "If you don't have room to fail, you don't have room to grow. — Jonathan Mildenhall
4. Positivity trickles down through the ranks. Negativity spreads faster, like fire.

5. Failure is not a sign of personal incompetence. It's just one experiment that has gone wrong. Move on the next level.
6. All you ever have to decide is what to do next. It really is this simple.
7. You don't rely on data or facts. You push the impossible.
8. You have everything you need to build something far bigger than yourself. ~Seth Godin
9. If you genuinely want something, don't wait for it — teach yourself to be impatient.- Gurbaksh Chahal
10. Finished last' will always be better than 'Did not finish', which always trumps 'Did not start.'
11. Growth begins at the end of your comfort zone.
12. Change for the better; don't change for someone else, change for yourself!
13. If you truly want to change your life, you must first change your mind.
14. Passion is about why we do what we do. Not what, how or when.
15. "Dare" might sound a bit over the top, but really it's a gentle warning. Dare, but tread lightly. Dare, but know you'll face stiff resistance at times.
16. Every accomplishment starts with the decision to try.
17. You have three choices in life: Give up, give in, or give it all you've got.
18. 'Finished last' will always be better than 'Did not finish', which always trumps 'Did not start.'
19. Unless you try to master something beyond what you already know, you will never grow.
20. Most great things in your life won't happen by chance, they will happen by choice.
21. No matter how many mistakes you make, or how slow you progress, you are still way ahead of everyone who isn't trying.

22. Do not wait until the conditions are perfect to begin. Beginning makes the conditions perfect.
23. Remember, being completely terrible at something is the first step to being pretty darn good at it.
24. What you do every day matters more than what you do every once in awhile.
25. The real world doesn't reward perfectionists. It rewards people who get things done.
26. Forget all the reasons it won't work and believe the one reason that it will." — Unknown
27. A setback is a setup for a comeback" -T.D. Jakes
28. Do or Do Not. There is no Try — Yoda.
29. Don't wait to be chosen. It's far more interesting to bet on yourself and find the guts you need to produce, the one who says 'go'.
30. "Life is not about finding yourself. Life is about creating yourself." — Lolly Daskal
31. "Your problem isn't the problem. Your reaction is the problem." — Anonymous
32. Don't be subject to the tyranny of "how things have always been done".Find your true north and push past the default.
33. Almost everyone can sprint. The road to mastery requires consistency.Everything meaningful in life is a marathon.
34. If you pursue your dreams long enough, compounding takes effect. Momentum will surge. Don't give up just yet.
35. Don't invest in a career. Build a life. Take your dreams seriously.
36. If you commit to nothing, you'll be distracted by everything.
37. "Decide what you want or someone else will.
38. You can't learn in school what the world is going to do next year. — Henry Ford

39. Give a damn. Many damns. More damns than anyone.
40. Progress is the ultimate motivation.
41. “Life is inherently risky. There is only one big risk you should avoid at all costs, and that is the risk of doing nothing.” — Denis Waitley
42. “The most important thing to remember is this: to be ready at any moment to give up what you are for what you might become.” — W. E. B. Du Bois

Timeless And Generally Applicable Pieces of Wisdom

“Don’t try to be different, own the fact you already are.” — Jonathan Fields

Words have power — and the ones in this post are guaranteed to challenge the way you think and perhaps even change the way you live. They have inspired me to choose life, persevere and live life to the full. Don’t give up on yourself just yet, your most amazing life is still ahead of you. Your very best work, project, experiences are in front of you, not behind you. Whether you feel stuck or just need a good dose of inspiration from great minds, these should do the trick.

1. Don’t try harder, try differently. If you’re trying to do something and it’s not working, and you try again and it’s not working again, take a step back and try to figure out if there’s a different way to go about doing things. This is applicable to everything from packing a truck to solving people problems.

2. “Everything around you that you call life was made up by people that were no smarter than you, and you can change it. You can influence it. You can build your own things that other people can use.” — Steve Jobs

3. The way you are today is most likely the way you will always be — change is hard. You can't even change yourself 10 percent. But you can change 10 things about yourself 1 percent. Make tiny changes you can sustain.

4. The human mind is naturally creative, constantly looking to make associations and connections between things and ideas. It wants to explore, to discover new aspects of the world, and to invent. To express this creative force is our greatest desire, and the stifling of it the source of our misery.

5. When you take a new job, negotiate for more vacation time, not for more money. Then take all your vacation every single year. You can always get more money — you can never get more time.

6. If you want to make something people really care about, that they actually give a holy shit about, you have to care about it yourself.

7. Money talks — it says "goodbye". Money will never love you, it can only buy comfort, not love or security or health or opportunity. Money is good to have but it's not the end goal. Loving another person is the end goal. As the song says, "The greatest thing you will ever learn is to love and be loved in return." Believe it.

8. Listen more than you talk. Whatever the context, people will think you're smarter" — Esther Dyson

9. Stop looking for shortcuts. No, really, stop. Read the whole book, not the Wikipedia summary. Think about it. Life is not a collection of sound bites.

10. Meaning" is a good thing. Life is pretty useless without it. And if you can find it in your work, even better, because that raises your odds of being successful considerably.

11. You may not be where you want to be but if you are at least trying you are better than everyone else who isn't trying moving or making progress.Somewhere inside you is something special. You just need the courage to let it out.
12. Think progress not perfection. In education when someone improves and moves closer to their goal but still struggles this is a good mantra to keep in mind. In education, as well as in life, instant improvement is rare.

In day to day life we seek to get better, and even if we still **** up now and then, thinking "progress, not perfection" will keep you motivated when you come up against a challenge.

13. Idleness will almost always lead to regret later. The secret to being happy and content, in general, is to do something of value to yourself and/or others regularly.

14. Show up everyday and work on your most important life work. Whether the outcome is magnificent or eternal, whether it changes people's lives, changes the world, changes you or groundbreaking, it matters that you show up.

15. "When you waste a moment, you have killed it in a sense, squandering an irreplaceable opportunity. But when you use the moment properly, filling it with purpose and productivity, it lives on forever." — Menachem Mendel Schneerson

16. "Don't think about why you question, simply don't stop questioning. Don't worry about what you can't answer, and don't try to explain what you can't know. Curiosity is its own reason. Aren't you in awe when you contemplate the mysteries of eternity, of

life, of the marvelous structure behind reality? And this is the miracle of the human mind — to use its constructions, concepts, and formulas as tools to explain what man sees, feels and touches. Try to comprehend a little more each day. Have holy curiosity." — Albert Einstein

17. When the pain of where you are is greater than the fear of where you are going, you will change.

18. "Don't ask what the world needs. Ask what makes you come alive, and go do it. Because what the world needs is people who have come alive."Howard Thurman

19. "The wisdom of the years tells me that growing old is a frame of mind, and the way to stay young is to listen to your dreams and to keep one's vision more ahead than behind" — Andy Russell

20. Once you understand that habits can be rebuilt, the power of habit becomes easier to grasp, and the only option left is to get to work." — Charles Duhigg

21. Giving up is always easier than holding on. Funny how people have the courage to miss out the potential and start all over again. Usually repeating the same mistakes over and over again. Don't give up just yet.

22. Every life is special. You matter. Your dreams matter. It's up to you to take action in the direction of your dreams, and when you do, you'll be met halfway — I promise. Pursue your ultimate potential, anything less is not worthy of your time

23. "We can know only that we know nothing. And that is the highest degree of human wisdom." — Leo Tolstoy

24. “All your life people will tell you things. And most of the time, probably ninety-five percent of the time, what they’ll tell you will be wrong.” — Michael Crichto

25. It may be safer and easier to say nothing but committing to having a point of view improves your thinking, your attitude and your trajectory.Speak up. Not just tomorrow, but every day.
26. Make no mistake. The world is waiting for you. Waiting for you to stop asking for permission. To stop questioning yourself. To stop listening to everyone else. Waiting for you to start something.

Waiting to hear what you have to say. Waiting to use your product. Waiting to share your ideas and creativity. You are the only one who can push yourself that further to just start.

27. Being noticed is not the same as being remarkable. Don’t get noticed for the wrong reasons. Be remarkable for your smartest and best work. You will be amazed at what you can do if you put your mind to it. Not everyone appreciates your efforts to be remarkable. In fact, most people don’t. But go for it anyway.

28. Start. Move, make, create, ship, do. Just start. That’s what entrepreneurs do. They start. They start something. Sometimes it is something big. Sometimes it is a big failure. Either way, they got sh** done.

These Sites Can Help You Get Better Everyday

“Intellectual growth should commence at birth and cease only at death.” — Albert Einstein

Learning should not end after formal education. Lifelong learning, the ongoing, voluntary, and self-motivated pursuit of knowledge can enrich your understanding of

different topics and make you a better person every day. Your career, personal life, and total well-being will never be the same if you can commit to some of these awesome resources.

1/ BBC — Future — In-depth coverage of science, health and technology
2/ 5-minute Drops: Learn a new language for no more than 5 minutes per day.
3/ Makezine: DIY projects, how-Tos, electronics, crafts and ideas for makers.
4/ Psychology Today is devoted exclusively to everybody's favorite subject: Ourselves.
5/ Daily Bits Of: Learn anything, anywhere, with daily courses via email.
6/ Skillshare for Mobile: Learn just about anything.
7/ Medium: Don't miss the amazing pieces here every week.
8/ The School of Life: A place that tries to answer the great questions of life with the help of culture.
9/ Chalk Street: Learn the things that are important to you.
10/ Guides.co: Modern "How To" guides.
11/ University of Reddit: Learn 1,000's of new things, from reddit.
12/ Highbrow: Expand your knowledge universe in just 5 minutes a day.
13/ InstaNerd: Be smart, instantly.
14/ Degreed: A lifelong learning platform.
15/ Daily Curiosity: Get informed with 5 new amazing topics, delivered daily.
16/ Lrn: Learn to code at your convenience.
17/ Flowkey: The easiest way to learn piano.
18/ Big Think: Articles and videos featuring expert "Big Thinkers."
19/ Code School: Learn to code by doing
20/ Lookmunk: Find the best websites to learn something new everyday!
21/ Greatist: Real facts and doable steps for your happiest life
22/ 99U (YouTube) — Actionable insights on productivity, organization, and leadership to help creative people push ideas forward.
23/ Youtube EDU — The education videos that unlock knowledge.

24/ WikiWand — A slick new interface for Wikipedia.

25/ The long read (The Guardian) — In-depth reporting, essays and profiles.

26/ TED Ideas— Insightful essays on creativity, ideas and global issues.

27/ iTunes U — Learning on the go, from some of the world's top universities.

28/ InsightfulQuestions (subreddit) — Intellectual discussions that are not necessarily genre-specific.

29/ Cerego — Cerego helps you build personalized study plans based on your strengths and weaknesses to retain knowledge.

30/ University of the People — Tuition-free online university that offers higher education in multiple course streams.

31/ OpenSesame — Marketplace for online training, now with 22,000+ courses.

32/ CreativeLive — Take free creative classes from the world's top experts.

33/ Thinkful — 1-on-1 coding mentorship to help advance your career.

34/ Zidbits: Huge collection of fun facts, weird news, and articles on a variety of topics.

35/ Quora — You ask, the net discusses — with top experts and fascinatingback and forth on everything.

16. Digital Photography School — Read through this goldmine of articles to improve your photography skills.

36/ Scientific American: Explores issues that matter including the human mind, earth, and space.

37/ Brain Pickings — Insightful long form posts on life, art, science, design, history, philosophy, and more.

38/ Peer 2 Peer University or P2PU, is an open educational project that helps you learn at your own pace.

39/ MIT Open CourseWare is a catalog of free online courses and learning resources offered by MIT.

40/ Gibbon — This is the ultimate playlist for learning.

41/ Investopedia — Learn everything you need to know about the world of investing, markets, and personal finance.

42/ Udacity offers interactive online classes and courses in higher education.

43/ Mozilla Developer Network offers detailed documentation and learning resources for web developers.

44/ Future learn — enjoy free online courses from top universities and specialist organisations.

45/ Google Scholar — provides a search of scholarly literature across many disciplines and sources, including theses, books, abstracts and articles.

47/ Brain Pump — A place to learn something new everyday.

47/ Mental Floss — Test your knowledge with amazing and interesting facts, trivia, quizzes, and brain teaser games.

48/ Learnist — Learn from expertly curated web, print and video content.

49/ DataCamp — Learn data science online.

50/ edX — Take online courses from the world's best universities.

51/ CoffeeStrap: Learn a language by meeting cool people.

52/ Coursmos — Take a micro-course anytime you want, on any device.

53/ Platzi — Live streaming classes on design, marketing and code.

54/ Alison: Free online courses from the world's top publishers.

55/ Course Buffet: Find and compare hundreds of free online courses.

56/ Now I Know: Learn something new every day, via email.

57/ Curious: Play the game of lifelong learning.

58/ Memrise: Learning, made joyful.

59/ Snapguide: How-to guides on all your favourite topics.

60/ 99U: Actionable insights on productivity and creativity.

61/ Nautilus: A magazine on science, culture, and philosophy for the intellectually curious.

62/ Aeon: A magazine of ideas and culture.